She knew nothing about my biography, less than nothing about my family. Granny, Willy, Pa—who're they? Better yet, she was remarkably incurious. She probably didn't even know about my mother; she was likely too young to recall the tragic events of August 1997. I couldn't be sure this was true, of course, because to Chelsy's credit we didn't talk about it. Instead we talked about the main thing we had in common—Africa. Chelsy, born and raised in Zimbabwe, now living in Cape Town, loved Africa with all her soul. Her father owned a big game farm, and that was the fulcrum of her world. Though she'd enjoyed her years at a British boarding school, Stowe, she'd always hurried home for the holidays. I told her I understood. I told her about my life-changing experiences in Africa, my first formative trips. I told her about the strange visitation from the leopard. She nodded. She got it. *Brilliant. Africa does offer moments like that, if you're ready. If you're worthy.*

At some point in the evening I told her I'd soon be entering the Army. I couldn't gauge her reaction. Maybe she had none? At least it didn't seem a deal-breaker.

Then I told her that George and Marko and I were all heading off the next day to Botswana. We were going to meet up with Adi, some others, float upriver. *Come with us?*

She smiled shyly, gave it a moment's thought. She and her girlfriend had other plans…

Oh. Too bad.

But they'd cancel them, she said. They'd love to come with us.

46.

WE SPENT THREE DAYS walking, laughing, drinking, mingling with the animals. Not just wild animals. By chance we met up with a snake wrangler, who showed us his cobra, his rattlesnake. He manipulated the snakes up and down his shoulders, his arms, giving us a private show.

Later that night, Chelsy and I had our first kiss under the stars.

George, meanwhile, fell head over heels in love with her girlfriend.